

Shannon L. Coleman, PhD

Strategy and Research Leader • AI Product Measurement • Regulated & Enterprise Markets

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[Ground Truth \(Substack\)](#) | [The Capability Question \(Research Tool\)](#) | [AI Calibration Audit Tool](#)

SUMMARY

Strategy and research leader with 15+ years across DoD modernization, enterprise AI, regulated HealthTech, and FinTech, including leading research and analytics teams of up to 25. Comes into complex, ambiguous situations, figures out what is actually true, and moves organizations toward better decisions. Equally fluent in a regression model and a 90-minute interview. Secret Clearance (Inactive).

KEY ACHIEVEMENTS

- **\$15B DoD Acquisition:** Drove the \$15B Advana multi-vendor recompetes, the largest defense AI and analytics platform contract in recent history, through a multi-method research program across ~1,400 enterprise users
- **AI Trust-Gap Evaluation, Advana:** Evaluated whether users acted on AI-generated recommendations or routinely overrode them on the DoD's flagship AI and analytics platform, reshaping how the Chief Digital and AI Office approached the platform's AI functionality and informing the \$15B multi-vendor recompetes decision
- **XLA Standards in \$5.7B Contracts:** Set the first contract-level UX performance standard for 800,000+ personnel by defining and operationalizing Experience Level Agreement standards embedded into \$5.7B Air Force EITaaS vendor contracts
- **16,000+ Users, First Six-Figure Agreement:** Built the Trust-Transfer Model, a B2B2C go-to-market framework, that grew an AI health platform from users in the hundreds and contributed to its first six-figure service agreement
- **~1,000 Participant Panel Built from Zero:** Reduced external recruitment spend to \$0 and cut study recruitment timelines by at least 2 weeks per study by building and scaling a nearly 1,000 participant proprietary research panel under HIPAA-adjacent and FDIC-regulated constraints

EXPERIENCE

Principal Strategy Advisor | Coleman Advisory

2022–Present

Independent consulting practice focused on mixed methods UX research and product strategy for early-stage HealthTech and FinTech platforms in regulated markets, working directly with founders and executive teams.

- **16,000+ Users, First Six-Figure Agreement:** Grew an AI-powered health platform from users in the hundreds by surfacing the “Not for Me” Paradox and a trust gap at onboarding; the resulting Trust-Transfer Model reoriented channel strategy toward self-funded employers, unions, and advocacy organizations
- **35–50% Faster Compliance Approval:** Reduced compliance approval cycles from 6–8 weeks to 3–5 weeks by integrating UX and regulatory communication as a single workstream from the start, eliminating late-stage engineering rework across design, legal, and engineering
- **\$50,000–\$65,000 in Engineering Costs Prevented:** Caught a churn-driving UX pattern in a 6-user prototype test before development began, improving task completion confidence by 35% and redirecting approximately 4 weeks of cross-functional team capacity
- **22% Projected Retention Lift, ~50% Fewer Support Tickets:** Diagnosed 17 transaction-state friction points concentrated in a single trust failure mode and delivered a unified UX and compliance roadmap

Research & Strategy Lead, DoD | Isobar Public Sector

2022–2024

Principal researcher and strategist for two large-scale DoD programs serving a combined 900,000+ users and personnel.

Advana | DoD CDAO Enterprise AI & Analytics Platform

- **~1,400 Enterprise Users, Multi-Method Research Program:** Established the evidentiary foundation for all subsequent AI platform and roadmap recommendations, spanning survey, interview, card sort, tree test, and two rounds of usability testing
- **Six Failure Modes Reframed as One Structural Challenge:** Directly informed a DoD-level development pause for infrastructure improvements on a platform that had scaled faster than its architecture, its UX, and its organizational support model
- **AI Trust-Gap Evaluation:** Surfaced a critical trust gap in Advana's AI capabilities by evaluating whether users acted on AI-generated recommendations or routinely overrode them, reshaping CDAO's approach to the platform's AI functionality
- **36% of Users Affected by a Content-Findability Crisis:** Diagnosed the issue as an information architecture failure rather than a user education problem, delivering the sitemap, navigation redesign, and content model to resolve it

- **\$15B Multi-Vendor Recompete, Two Product Roadmaps:** Contributed by delivering findings and strategic recommendations directly to the Chief Experience Architect and Chief Product Officer

Air Force EITaaS | Enterprise IT Modernization (\$5.7B program)

- **84% Faster Startup, 59% Faster Data Transfer, 92% Less Security Workload:** Drove these gains by developing a persona and workflow research framework across nine deployment sites, establishing the segmentation foundation that enabled XLA standard definition
- **800,000+ Personnel, XLA Standards in \$5.7B Contracts:** Institutionalized UX performance expectations by defining and operationalizing Experience Level Agreement (XLA) standards embedded into vendor contracts
- **74/100 Satisfaction vs. 44 Baseline:** Validated the program model before the Air Force committed to scaling by measuring IT satisfaction against comparable pre-transition bases, with speed satisfaction at 73 versus mid-40s elsewhere
- **U.S. Air Force Commander's Challenge Coin:** Awarded for shifting IT modernization to a user-centric service model, setting foundational standards for DAF digital transformation

Research & Strategy Analyst | Crowley Webb / Praxis

2020–2022

- **\$0 External Recruitment Spend, ~1,000-Participant Panel:** Cut study recruitment timelines by at least 2 weeks per study by building and scaling a research panel from zero under HIPAA-adjacent and FDIC-regulated constraints
- **F100 Pharma Trial Recruitment Gains (Pfizer, Eli Lilly, Merck, J&J, AbbVie):** Increased signups by conducting qualitative interviews, large-scale surveys, social listening, and patient experience research that directly informed site selection adjustments and messaging changes
- **Multi-Million-Dollar Phase II/III Campaigns:** Improved recruitment conversion by applying quantitative analysis to real-time performance insights, driving site selection adjustments, messaging changes, and budget reallocation
- **2–4 Days Faster per Study:** Reduced overall project timelines and eliminated redundant overhead by managing research operations for a 7–10 person team and standardizing recruitment workflows across concurrent client programs

Doctoral Researcher | University at Buffalo, Psychology & Quantitative Methods

2014–2019

- **Multi-Year Longitudinal Study, Dropout Risk Modeling:** Led mixed methods research integrating qualitative and advanced quantitative modeling, applying survival analysis and logistic regression to high-dimensional behavioral datasets
- **60%+ Interrater Reliability Gain, 25-Person Team:** Managed a research operations team, reducing costly re-coding cycles, producing consistently defensible findings, and strengthening the evidentiary basis for policy recommendations presented at the White House

EARLY CAREER

- **4-Product Category Launch, 100+ Concepts Evaluated (Fisher-Price):** Informed the launch by leading usability and developmental research in partnership with Product, Engineering, and Design
- **35,000+ Survey Responses, 30+ Pharma Brands (Segmedica, Inc.):** Designed and analyzed a national survey, packaged into a proprietary strategic research product

EDUCATION

PhD & MA, Psychology & Quantitative Methods — University at Buffalo, State University of New York

BS, Education — Fredonia, State University of New York

CORE EXPERTISE

Research Methods: Mixed methods research, usability testing and prototype validation, in-depth interviews and contextual inquiry, survey design and quantitative analysis, longitudinal and behavioral data modeling, survival analysis, logistic regression, A/B testing

AI Evaluation & Measurement: AI trust and adoption research, model calibration and confidence-vs-correctness evaluation, AI capability measurement, AI-assisted research workflows

Product & Strategy: Product roadmapping, strategic framework development, go-to-market research, XLA and CX measurement, persona and segmentation frameworks, information architecture, Agile research integration

Research Operations: Research program design, panel development and management, research ops standardization, cross-functional research leadership, compliance-driven research (HIPAA, GDPR, ISO 27001:2022)

Domains: AI products, HealthTech, GovTech / DoD, enterprise platforms, regulated and compliance-driven systems, classified environments, Web3 / FinTech

Tools & Platforms: Qualtrics, dscout, Figma, Miro, UserTesting, Optimal Workshop, Dovetail, R, SPSS, Tableau, Power BI, Azure SQL, GA4, Google Search Console, Jira, Confluence, ServiceNow, GitHub

AI Tools: Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, Dovetail AI, Notion AI, Otter.ai, Miro Assist